CASE STUDY | DELHI

"My heart attack taught me the importance of minimising stress"



DR AMITABH BHARDWAJ, *49*

Doctor, Indira Gandhi Institute of Cardiology, Patna

Since his own father had suffered a heart attack at the age of 39, Dr Amitabh knew he had a risk factor for heart disease. Stress and work, however, kept him from adopting a lifestyle that was heart-friendly. "I was mostly glued to my desk and left the chair only to check on a patient and then immediately returned to it. I also had a lot of mental stress caused by my job and the usual business of life," says the 49-year-old doctor at the Indira Gandhi Institute of Cardiology in Patna.

His lifestyle caught up with him in May 2016. Dr Amitabh was 43 at the time and had gone to visit a colleague. The elevator was not working that day and he had to take the stairs to reach a sixth floor apartment. By the time he reached the fifth floor, he collapsed from breathlessness and severe chest pain. Residents of the building carried him to a bed and, realising that he was having a heart attack, Dr Amitabh immediately took a mononitrate tablet, a medicine commonly taken to relieve chest pain and unblock clogged arteries. "I was then rushed to the hospital where an angiography found blockage in my right artery. I had to go through an emergency angioplasty and was in the ICU for six days," he says.

After a month's rest, Dr Amitabh says he changed his approach to health and life completely. Even though seven tablets daily keep his heart going, he has also cut out potato, rice, sugar and fried food from his diet and switched to fruit and green vegetables with roti. He also walks every day. Most, importantly, he has minimised his stress. "I believe I am a more responsible person now—towards myself and others," he says.

–Amitabh Srivastava

veg shaami kebab wrap 1.48 gm of salt. A Mcspicy paneer burger at McDonald's has 17.12 gm of saturated fat, more than a packet of regular fries here, and a single serving of its ghee rice with Mcspicy chicken has about 2.3 gm of salt. And you may not associate it with a burger, but a Burger King masala veg whopper has 11.8 gm of sugar.

"The amount of salt, sugar and saturated fats an average urban Indian consumes has surged," observes noted cardiologist Dr Anita Saxena, vice-chancellor at the Pt B.D. Sharma University, PGIMS, Rohtak, and former dean of academics at AIIMS. "I often get patients who say they are vegetarian and are then surprised to find they have high blood pressure or high cholesterol." Overconsumption of sugar, salt and fat over time cause diseases that wreak havoc on your heart. Excessive salt intake, for instance, causes the body to retain water. The increased fluid, in turn, raises the blood pressure. This means blood is pumped into the heart with greater force, damaging its walls. Too much sugar has somewhat the same effect but worse—it also causes chronic inflammation of fat cells that leads to a build-up of both bad cholesterol and a rise in blood pressure. The US-based CDC (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention) says that those with Type 2 diabetes are twice as likely to have heart disease and at a younger age than most. High amounts of cholesterol brought on by excess fatty food and sugar intake increase the build-up of plaque in the arteries, causing blockages.

Max Healthcare nutritionist Dr Megha Jaina blames it on people's tendency to ignore nutrition labels on their foods. "Many of my patients say we don't have chocolate, sodas or chips, items we know are high in unhealthy nutrients. But then they eat packets of 'no sugar added' cornflakes, which are high in salt. We don't associate salt with cereals, or sugar with savoury food items," she says. A study of 10,500 Indian processed food products by AIIMS and North Carolina University at Chapel Hill found that only 32 per cent of the items met WHO standards. The longer the exposure to these conditions, the earlier the risk of heart disease and attacks. "Too many lifestyle diseases are coming up too early in the younger generation," says Dr Shashidhar, head